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1929, The Enigma

Rajmohan Gandhi, a grandson of Mahatma Gandhi, has recently observed that ‘the romance of many in the twenty-first century India with the Bhagat Singh legend is not necessarily an accurate indication of the political realities of the Punjab of the heroes own time’. The view is an uncharitable one. For him, ‘Punjab’s Muslims were generally not drawn to the agenda of the revolutionaries, and Sikh involvement too was minimal.’ As he explains, ‘The list of the eighteen men accused in May 1930 in the Lahore Conspiracy Case, as it was called, contains no Muslim name and one Sikh name, that of Bhagat Singh. Five others who had absconded and five who had turned approver were also, it seems, Hindus. Moreover, many of the twenty-eight charged were from outside Punjab.’[1] However, it is surely remiss of him to overlook the fact that whereas five of them were from Kanpur, some of the leading figures were from Punjab. Bhagat Singh, Bhagwati Charan and Yashpal were from Lahore. Sukhdev was from Lyallpur. Kishori Rattan Lal was from Hoshiarpur. And both Des Raj and Agya Ram were from Sialkot. That is a significant Punjabi presence in the conspiracy. HSRA was a nation-wide movement in any event and drew its recruits from across the country. Punjabis do not exaggerate their role in the revolutionary movement if their overall involvement in India’s freedom movement is considered, which is by no stretch of imagination insignificant. Bhagat Singh himself belonged to a family of revolutionaries. Moreover, as Kuldip Nayyar[2] explains, the government lawyer Carden Noad, at the beginning of the trial, had said that there were twenty-eight accused in all. Of these five had absconded and five had turned witness for